

THE SLOW ATLAS

Thailand

The Complete Guide

Where to go, what to eat, and how to travel it slowly.



A SLOW ATLAS GUIDE • VOLUME I

WELCOME

Sawatdee – welcome

There is nowhere quite like Thailand. In a single trip you can wake to mist over northern mountains, ride a scooter past golden temples, eat the best meal of your life from a plastic stool on a side-street, and fall asleep to waves on a southern shore. It is dazzling, warm, deeply hospitable — and wonderfully easy to travel.

This guide is written for the traveller who wants more than a checklist. It is built to help you travel slowly and well: to understand the country, plan with confidence, and leave room for the unplanned afternoons that become the best memories.

HOW THIS GUIDE IS ARRANGED

- Before you go — timing, documents, health and what to pack.
- Budget — what Thailand really costs, with sample spends.
- Destinations — the unmissable places, region by region.
- Ready-to-use itineraries — 10 to 14 days, planned for you.
- Getting around & where to stay.
- Food, activities, practical tips and a phrasebook.

HOW TO TRAVEL IT SLOWLY

- Choose one or two regions, not all four.
- Build in empty days — Thailand rewards lingering.
- Eat where the locals queue; say yes to the unfamiliar.
- Learn ten words of Thai; you'll be met with warmth.
- Move by day, on the ground, to see the country in between.



PART ONE

Before you go

Timing, paperwork and packing – sorted.



THE SLOW ATLAS

When to go

OI

Choosing the right window matters more in Thailand than almost anywhere — and the north and south often run on different clocks.

Cool & dry

NOV – FEB

The sweet spot: comfortable days, clear skies, cool hill evenings. Peak season — book ahead, especially over New Year.

Hot

MAR – MAY

Fierce heat (35–40°C). Mar–Apr brings crop-burning haze to the north. Songkran (13–15 Apr) is a nationwide water-fight new year.

Green & wet

JUN – OCT

Warm monsoon — short, heavy afternoon bursts rather than all-day rain. Lush, quiet and cheap; the Andaman coast is wettest.

A MONTH-BY-MONTH ALMANAC

MONTH	WEATHER	DON'T MISS
Jan	Cool, dry, ideal	Peak season
Feb	Warm, dry	Chiang Mai Flower Fest
Mar	Hot, northern haze	Sea & islands shine
Apr	Hottest	Songkran water festival
May	Hot, first rains	Low season begins
Jun	Warm, wet spells	Green & cheap

MONTH	WEATHER	DON'T MISS
Jul	Monsoon	Asalha Puja / Lent
Aug	Wettest in places	Quiet, lush north
Sep	Heavy rains	Lowest prices
Oct	Rains ease	Vegetarian Festival
Nov	Cool, dry returns	Loy Krathong / Yi Peng
Dec	Cool, dry, busy	High season

Documents, health & money

ENTRY & VISAS

- Many nationalities (EU, UK, US, Australia, Canada...) enter visa-free for short stays — the exact number of days changes, so confirm the current rule for your passport before you fly.
- Passport valid 6+ months beyond arrival, with blank pages.
- Have proof of onward travel and accommodation ready.
- Longer stays / multiple entries: apply for the right visa in advance.
- Never overstay — fines are charged per day at the airport.

HEALTH & VACCINATIONS

- See a travel clinic 6–8 weeks ahead for current advice.
- Routine jabs up to date; Hepatitis A & typhoid commonly advised.
- Dengue is mosquito-borne — repellent dusk & dawn, no vaccine for travellers.
- Comprehensive travel insurance is essential — and it **MUST** cover motorbikes if you'll ride.
- Tap water isn't safe to drink; bottled or filtered only.

MONEY

- The baht (THB) is cash-first outside cities; carry small notes.
- ATMs everywhere but charge ≈THB 220 per foreign withdrawal — take more, less often.
- Cards work in malls, hotels and chains; markets are cash only.
- Tell your bank you're travelling; bring a backup card kept separately.
- Tipping isn't expected; rounding up is a kind gesture.

CONNECTIVITY

- Buy a tourist SIM (AIS, TrueMove, dtac) at the airport, or an eSIM before you fly.
- Data is fast and cheap; coverage is excellent outside the deep mountains.
- Save offline maps for road trips.

What to pack

03

Thailand is hot, humid and casual — pack light, in natural fabrics, and leave room for what you'll buy. Laundry is cheap and everywhere, so a week's worth of clothes is plenty.

CLOTHING

- Light, loose, quick-dry clothes
- One set covering shoulders & knees (temples)
- A light layer for cool northern evenings & buses
- Swimwear + a sarong (modesty, beach, picnic)
- Comfortable walking sandals + trainers
- A packable rain jacket or poncho

HEALTH & ESSENTIALS

- High-SPF, reef-safe sunscreen + sun hat
- Insect repellent (DEET) & after-bite
- Small first-aid kit, rehydration salts, your meds
- Hand sanitiser & tissues (not all toilets have paper)
- Universal adapter & power bank
- Refillable water bottle (cut the plastic)

DOCUMENTS TO CARRY (PAPER + DIGITAL COPIES)

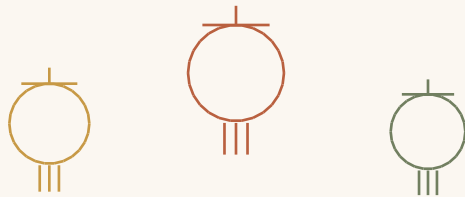
- Passport, visa, travel insurance details
- Driving licence + International Driving Permit (if driving)
- Card details / emergency numbers stored offline
- A few passport photos for any on-the-spot paperwork



PART TWO

Budget

What it really costs — and how to travel for less.



THE SLOW ATLAS

What Thailand costs

Thailand suits every budget. You can travel beautifully on very little, or indulge for a fraction of European prices. Here's what to expect per person, per day, once you're in the country.

STYLE	PER DAY	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE
Backpacker	THB 900–1,500	Hostels & fan rooms, street food, scooters, public transport
Comfort	THB 2,500–4,500	Smart guesthouses & 3-star hotels, mix of restaurants, some flights & tours
Boutique	THB 6,000+	Design hotels & resorts, private drivers, spas, fine dining

SAMPLE 2-WEEK COMFORT BUDGET (PER PERSON) PRICES TO ANCHOR ON

ITEM	THB
Accommodation (13 nights)	16,000
Food & drink	9,000
Transport & 1–2 flights	7,000
Activities & tours	6,000
Scooter / car & fuel	3,500
SIM, extras, buffer	3,500

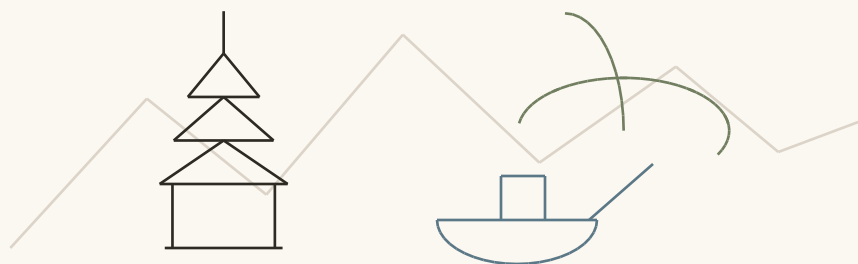
≈ THB 45,000 · roughly €1,150 / £980 / \$1,250

- Street meal: THB 50–80
- Restaurant main: THB 120–250
- Local beer: THB 70–100
- Coffee: THB 50–80
- Scooter hire: THB 200–300/day
- Litre of petrol: ≈THB 40
- Guesthouse double: THB 600–1,200
- Domestic flight: THB 1,000–2,500
- Long train (2nd class): THB 200–900
- Day tour: THB 800–1,800

PART THREE

Destinations

The unmissable places, region by region.



THE SLOW ATLAS

The lie of the land

05

Thailand falls into four broad regions. Don't try to cover them all — choose one or two and travel them slowly.

The North

Mountains, Lanna temples, hill tribes, the best road trips and cool air. Chiang Mai, Pai, Mae Hong Son.

The Centre

Bangkok's energy, ancient Ayutthaya, the River Kwai, beaches at Hua Hin. The hub you'll likely arrive in.

Isaan (NE)

Khmer ruins, silk villages, the Mekong, fiery food, few tourists, big welcomes.

The South

Two coasts of islands, karsts and rainforest. Phuket, Krabi, Khao Sok, Koh Lanta, the Gulf isles.



Schematic — not to scale

Thailand's electric capital is a city of contrasts: glittering temples beside neon malls, river life beside skytrains, and some of the best street food on earth. Give it two or three days — it grows on you fast.

DON'T MISS

- The Grand Palace & Wat Phra Kaew (Emerald Buddha)
- Wat Pho's reclining Buddha & a temple massage
- Wat Arun at sunset, from across the river
- A long-tail boat through the Thonburi canals (khlongs)
- Chatuchak weekend market — 15,000 stalls
- Chinatown (Yaowarat) after dark, for street food

GOOD TO KNOW

- Get around by BTS Skytrain, MRT metro and river boats — fast and cheap.
- Use metered taxis or Grab; agree tuk-tuk fares first.
- Dress modestly for temples (shoulders & knees covered).
- Base yourself near the river (Old Town) or by a BTS station (Sukhumvit).

EAT & DRINK HERE

- Pad krapow and boat noodles from street stalls
- Mango sticky rice from a market cart
- Yaowarat (Chinatown) for seafood, dim sum and sweets
- A rooftop bar for the skyline (smart-casual dress)



Chiang Mai & the North

07

The cultural capital of the north is laid-back, green and endlessly likeable — a moat-ringed old town of 300 temples, fringed by mountains, cooking schools and coffee. The gateway to Pai, Mae Hong Son and the great northern road trips.

DON'T MISS

- The old-city temples — Wat Chedi Luang, Wat Phra Singh
- Doi Suthep temple, on the mountain above the city
- A day at an ethical elephant sanctuary (no riding)
- A Thai cooking class & the Sunday Walking Street
- Pai — a bohemian mountain town (3h north)
- The Mae Hong Son Loop (see itineraries)

GOOD TO KNOW

- Cool, especially Nov–Feb; pack a light layer.
- Avoid Mar–Apr burning season (smoky air).
- Rent a scooter to explore — or hire a car for the loop.
- Yi Peng & Loy Krathong (Nov) fill the sky with lanterns.

EAT & DRINK HERE

- Khao soi — the north's coconut-curry noodle bowl
- Sai ua (herby sausage) & nam prik dips
- Khao niao (sticky rice) with everything
- Northern coffee, grown in the surrounding hills



The South & islands

Postcard Thailand: limestone karsts rising from turquoise seas, rainforest national parks, and an island for every mood. Two coasts mean there's almost always somewhere dry — when the Andaman rains, cross to the Gulf.

DON'T MISS

- Railay & Ao Nang (Krabi) — climbers' cliffs & beaches
- Phang Nga Bay by long-tail or kayak
- Khao Sok National Park — jungle lake & raft-houses
- Koh Lanta — long, mellow west-coast beaches
- The Gulf isles — Ko Samui, Ko Pha-ngan, Ko Tao (diving)
- The Similan Islands for snorkelling & diving (seasonal)

GOOD TO KNOW

- Andaman coast (Krabi, Phuket): best Nov–Apr.
- Gulf coast (Samui, Tao): driest Feb–Apr & Jul–Aug.
- Ferries link the islands; book ahead in high season.
- Reef-safe sunscreen only — protect the coral.

EAT & DRINK HERE

- Fresh seafood, grilled by the beach
- Southern curries — rich, turmeric-gold, fiery
- Massaman curry — mild and fragrant
- Fruit shakes and fresh coconut



Ayutthaya, Kanchanaburi & Isaan

09

Beyond the headline sights lies a quieter, history-rich Thailand — easy add-ons from Bangkok, or a route all their own.

DON'T MISS

- Ayutthaya — the romantic ruins of the old capital (1h from Bangkok)
- Kanchanaburi — the River Kwai, Death Railway & Erawan Falls
- Khao Yai National Park — waterfalls, gibbons & vineyards
- Phimai & Phanom Rung — Khmer temples older than Angkor
- The Mekong towns — Nong Khai & the surreal Sala Keoku
- Silk-weaving villages and som-tam country in Isaan

GOOD TO KNOW

- Ayutthaya: rent a bike to ride between the temples.
- Kanchanaburi: an easy, beautiful long weekend from Bangkok.
- Isaan: little English, the warmest welcomes, lowest prices.
- Trains and buses link it all; a car gives you the villages.

EAT & DRINK HERE

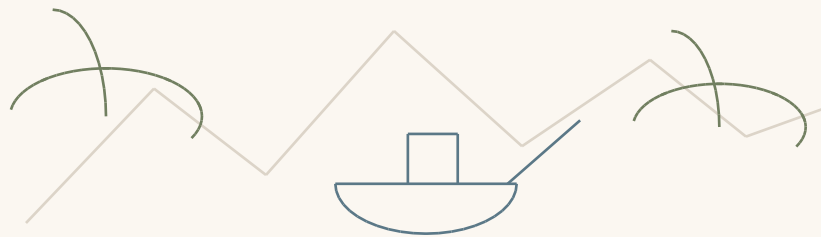
- Som tam (green-papaya salad) — Isaan's icon
- Larb & gai yang (grilled chicken) with sticky rice
- Sai krok Isan — sour fermented sausage
- Mekong river fish, simply grilled



PART FOUR

Ready-to-use itineraries

Three trips, planned for you – adapt and go.



THE SLOW ATLAS

10 days · The North

10

Mountains, temples and the legendary Mae Hong Son Loop, from a Chiang Mai base. Fly in and out of Chiang Mai. Best Nov–Feb.

D1–2 Chiang Mai

Old-city temples, a cooking class, an ethical elephant visit and the night markets.

D3 To Pai

Ride the 762 curves north; waterfalls and coffee stops on the way.

D4 Pai

Canyon at dawn, hot springs, white temple at sunset.

D5 To Mae Hong Son

Tham Lod cave and the bamboo bridge; a calm, Shan-flavoured town.

D6 Mae Hong Son

Ban Rak Thai tea village and misty viewpoints.

D7 To Mae Sariang

A quiet riverside town on the loop's western arm.

D8 To Doi Inthanon

Climb Thailand's highest peak; twin pagodas and waterfalls.

D9–10 Chiang Mai

Massage, markets and a slow finish before flying out.



Schematic — not to scale

12 days · Islands & South

II

Karsts, rainforest and beaches down the Andaman coast, finishing island-slow. Fly into Phuket, out of Krabi (or vice-versa). Best Nov–Apr.

D1–2 **Phuket**

Old-town shophouses and a first beach; ease into island time.

D3 **Phang Nga Bay**

Long-tail or kayak among the sea-stacks and hidden lagoons.

D4–5 **Khao Sok**

Jungle lake by raft-house; dawn mist, gibbons and caves.

D6–8 **Krabi, Ao Nang & Railay**

Climbers' karsts, beach-hopping and a boat to cliff-ringed Railay.

D9–11 **Koh Lanta**

Long, quiet beaches; sunsets and old-town seafood.

D12 **To Krabi & home**

A last swim before the flight out.



Schematic — not to scale

14 days · Best of Thailand

12

Bangkok, the cultural north and the southern islands, linked by two short internal flights. The classic first-timer's grand tour.

D1-3 Bangkok

Temples, river life, Chinatown food and a day-trip to Ayutthaya's ruins.

D4 Fly to Chiang Mai

Evening at the night bazaar.

D5-7 Chiang Mai

Temples, cooking class, ethical elephants and Doi Suthep.

D8-9 Pai or the hills

A taste of the mountains — slow and scenic.

D10 Fly south to Krabi

Swap mountains for the sea.

D11-13 Krabi & islands

Railay, Ao Nang and a day among the karsts.

D14 Home

One last Thai breakfast before the airport.

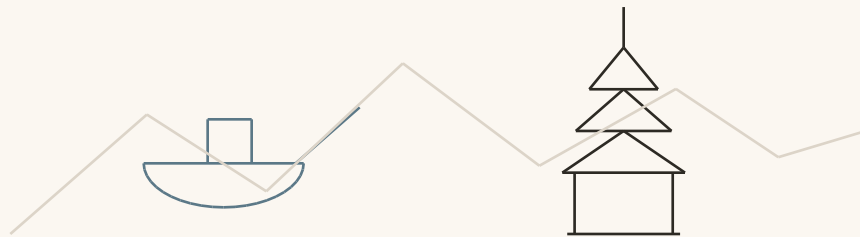


Schematic — not to scale

PART FIVE

Getting around & staying

How to move, and where to lay your head.



THE SLOW ATLAS

Transport

BETWEEN CITIES

- Domestic flights are cheap and quick (AirAsia, Nok, Thai Lion, Bangkok Airways) — ideal for north-south.
- Trains are scenic and characterful; the overnight sleeper to Chiang Mai is a classic (book ahead, 2nd-class A/C).
- Long-distance buses & minivans reach everywhere; comfortable 'VIP' coaches on big routes.
- Book trains, buses and ferries online via 12Go.

ON THE ISLANDS & COAST

- Ferries & speedboats link the islands — rougher and reduced in monsoon.
- Long-tail boats for short hops and hidden beaches (agree the price).
- Songthaews (shared pick-ups) run fixed routes for a few baht.

AROUND TOWN

- Bangkok: BTS Skytrain + MRT metro are fast, cheap and air-conditioned.
- Grab (and Bolt) for metered, hassle-free rides — pay in-app.
- Metered taxis: insist on the meter ('meter, please').
- Tuk-tuks: fun but agree the fare first; not always cheaper.
- Motorbike taxis (orange vests) for quick solo hops.

SELF-DRIVING

- Carry an International Driving Permit + your licence; checkpoints are common.
- Drive on the LEFT; give way to bigger vehicles.
- Scooters (THB 200–300/day) suit the north; never leave your passport as deposit.
- Helmets are law; insurance must cover motorbikes.
- Avoid night driving on rural roads.

Accommodation

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Thailand offers some of the best-value beds in the world — from £6 hostel bunks to design hotels that would cost five times more in Europe. Book the first and last nights ahead; improvise the middle.

TYPE	£ / NIGHT	BEST FOR
Hostel / guesthouse	THB 200–700	Backpackers, solo travellers, meeting people
Boutique guesthouse	THB 800–1,800	Character and comfort without the price
3–4★ hotel / resort	THB 1,800–4,500	Pools, breakfast, families
Design / luxury	THB 5,000+	Special occasions, honeymoons
Homestay / raft-house	THB 500–1,500	Villages, national parks, real local life

WHERE TO BASE YOURSELF

- Bangkok: Old Town (river, temples) or Sukhumvit (BTS, nightlife).
- Chiang Mai: inside or just outside the old-city moat.
- Krabi: Ao Nang for access; Railay to wake by the cliffs.
- Islands: west coast for sunsets; quieter beaches need a scooter.

BOOKING TIPS

- Read recent reviews for cleanliness, noise and Wi-Fi.
- A/C vs fan: worth it in the lowlands; fan is fine up north.
- High season (Nov–Feb) & holidays: book well ahead.
- Walk-in deals exist off-season — bargain politely.
- Check the location pin, not just the photos.



PART SIX

Food & drink

How to eat brilliantly, anywhere.



THE SLOW ATLAS

How to eat in Thailand

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STREET FOOD, DECODED

- The best meals come from carts and tiny shophouses — follow the crowds of locals.
- Many stalls cook one dish brilliantly; point if you can't pronounce it.
- Sit, eat, pay after; a bowl of noodles is THB 50–80.
- Markets cluster at dawn and dusk — arrive hungry.
- Busy + fresh + hot = safe. Watch it cooked.

SPICE & ORDERING

- 'Mai phet' = not spicy; 'phet nit noi' = a little (still a lot!).
- Season at the table: fish sauce, chilli, sugar, vinegar.
- Rice ('khao') is the centre; share dishes family-style.
- Eat with spoon & fork — the fork pushes, the spoon delivers.

VEGETARIAN & ALLERGIES

- 'Mangsawirat' = vegetarian; 'jay' = strict vegan — look for the yellow-red '๑ ๑' flag.
- Fish sauce & shrimp paste hide everywhere — 'mai sai nam pla / mai sai kapi'.
- Peanuts are common; carry an allergy translation card.
- The annual Vegetarian Festival (Oct) is a feast for plant-eaters.

WHAT TO DRINK

- Cha yen — sweet orange iced tea.
- Nam manao — fresh lime soda.
- Fruit shakes ('mai sai nam tan' for no sugar).
- Singha, Chang & Leo — ice-cold local beers.
- Roadside coffee — Café Amazon is everywhere.

What to order · North & Centre

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THE NORTH

Khao soi — the crown — egg noodles in coconut curry, crisp noodles on top

Sai ua — herby grilled Chiang Mai sausage

Nam prik num — smoky green-chilli dip with sticky rice & veg

Gaeng hang lay — rich Burmese-style pork curry

Khanom jeen nam ngiao — rice noodles in a tomato-pork broth

Khao niao — sticky rice — eaten by hand

CENTRAL & BANGKOK

Pad krapow — holy-basil stir-fry + fried egg — the comfort dish

Tom yum goong — hot-and-sour prawn soup

Tom kha gai — coconut-galangal chicken soup

Pad thai — the famous wok noodles

Khao man gai — Hainanese chicken & rice

Massaman — mild, fragrant curry of Persian roots

Mango sticky rice — the dessert — khao niao mamuang



What to order · Isaan & South

16

ISAAN (NORTH-EAST)

Som tam — pounded green-papaya salad — order 'phet nit noi'

Larb — zingy minced-meat salad, herbs & toasted rice

Gai yang — marinated grilled chicken

Sai krok Isan — sour fermented pork sausage

Nam tok — 'waterfall' grilled-beef salad

Khao niao — sticky rice — the staple here

THE SOUTH & SWEETS

Gaeng tai pla — intense southern fish curry — for the brave

Khao yam — fresh herbal rice salad

Massaman / seafood curries — coconut-rich, fragrant, often milder

Grilled seafood — by the beach, with nam jim seafood dip

Roti — griddled banana-and-egg pancake

Fresh fruit — mangosteen, rambutan, durian (if you dare)

MARKET WISDOM

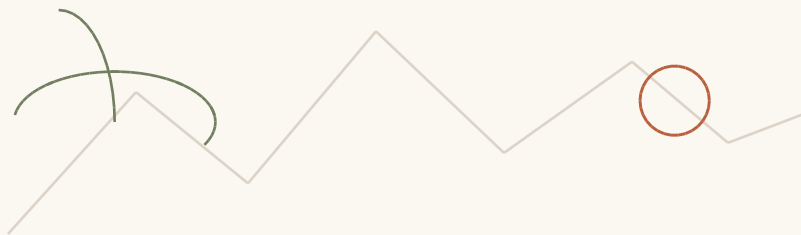
- Morning markets for fruit, coffee and rice dishes; night markets for grills, noodles and sweets.
- Order from several stalls and share — that's the joy of it.
- A bag of cut fruit with chilli-salt is the perfect THB-20 snack.



PART SEVEN

Activities & experiences

The things you'll still talk about years later.



THE SLOW ATLAS

Things to do

CULTURE & SPIRIT

- Temple-hop the great wats — go early, dress modestly.
- Give alms to monks at dawn, respectfully.
- Watch (or join) Loy Krathong & Yi Peng lanterns in Nov.
- Learn the craft at a Thai cooking class — a half-day highlight.
- A traditional Thai massage (from THB 250/hour).

MOUNTAINS & JUNGLE

- Trek to hill-tribe villages and waterfalls in the north.
- Ride the Mae Hong Son Loop by scooter or car.
- Kayak the jungle lake at Khao Sok; spot gibbons at Khao Yai.
- Chase waterfalls — Erawan's seven turquoise tiers.

SEA & ISLANDS

- Snorkel or dive — Ko Tao is a world-famous (cheap) place to learn.
- Long-tail or kayak through Phang Nga & Krabi's karsts.
- Island-hop by ferry; find a beach with no name.
- Sunset from a long-tail, then seafood on the sand.

WITH ANIMALS — ETHICALLY

- Choose genuine elephant sanctuaries where elephants roam and are never ridden — research first.
- Avoid riding, shows and tiger selfies.
- Watch wildlife in national parks, at a respectful distance.

PART EIGHT

Practical tips & language

Travel smart, travel kind, and say hello.



THE SLOW ATLAS

Culture & etiquette

DO

- Return a 'wai' (palms together) with a smile.
- Dress modestly at temples — shoulders & knees covered; shoes off.
- Keep calm; a smile defuses almost anything ('jai yen').
- Give and receive with your right hand, or both.
- Ask before photographing people.

DON'T

- Touch anyone's head — even a child's.
- Point your feet at people or Buddha images.
- Raise your voice or show anger ('losing face').
- Disrespect the monarchy — it is against the law.
- Women: don't touch or hand things directly to monks.

THE IDEAS BEHIND IT

Two words explain a lot of Thailand. 'Sanuk' is the belief that life — even work — should have an element of fun. 'Jai yen', a 'cool heart', prizes calm and composure over confrontation. And 'mai pen rai' — never mind, it's fine — is a whole gentle philosophy of letting things go.

AT THE TEMPLE (WAT)

- Cover up, remove shoes & hat, lower your voice.
- Sit with feet tucked behind you, not toward the Buddha.
- A small donation helps with upkeep.
- Never climb on ruins or Buddha images for a photo.

Staying safe & smart

COMMON SCAMS — SMILE & DECLINE

- 'The temple/palace is closed today' — it isn't; the tout has a gem shop to show you.
- Cheap tuk-tuk 'tours' that detour to commission stops.
- Rigged taxi meters — insist on the meter or agree a price first.
- Jet-ski / scooter 'damage' claims — photograph everything at pickup.
- Over-friendly strangers with card games or 'free' drinks.

HEALTH ON THE ROAD

- Drink bottled/filtered water only; ice in cafés is usually fine.
- Eat where it's busy and freshly cooked.
- Carry rehydration salts; pace the heat and hydrate.
- Pharmacies are excellent and cheap for minor ailments.

SENSIBLE & SAFE

- Thailand is generally very safe; petty theft is the main risk.
- Use hotel safes; keep a card and some cash separate.
- Women travel widely and easily — usual night-time sense applies.
- Respect the sea — heed red flags and rip-current warnings.
- Buy travel insurance that covers motorbikes if you'll ride.

EMERGENCY NUMBERS

- Police 191 · Ambulance 1669
- Tourist Police (English) 1155
- Tourism Authority (TAT) 1672

TRAVEL KINDLY

- Refill a bottle; reef-safe sunscreen; bin nothing in nature.
- Spend with local families, markets and guides.

A Thai phrasebook · I

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ESSENTIALS

Hello — sawatdee (khrap/kha)
Thank you — khop khun (khrap/kha)
Yes / No — chai / mai chai
Please — karuna
Sorry / excuse me — khor thot
No worries — mai pen rai
Do you speak English? — phut angkrit dai mai?
I don't understand — mai khao jai
My name is... — phom/chan chue...

NUMBERS

1 nung · 2 song · 3 sam · 4 si · 5 ha · 6 hok · 7 jet · 8 paet
 · 9 kao · 10 sip · 20 yi-sip · 100 nung roi · 1,000 nung
 phan

GETTING AROUND

Where is...? — ...yu thi nai?
How much? — tao rai?
Too expensive — phaeng pai
Turn left / right — liao sai / liao khwa
Straight on — trong pai
Stop here — jort thi ni
Bus / train station — sathani rot / rot fai
Petrol station — pam nam man
Toilet — hong nam

A Thai phrasebook · II

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AT THE TABLE

Delicious! — aroi!
Not spicy, please — mai phet
A little spicy — phet nit noi
Vegetarian / vegan — mangsawirat / jay
No fish sauce — mai sai nam pla
The bill, please — check bin
Water — nam plao
Cheers! — chon kaew!
I'm allergic to... — phae...

TIME & SMALL TALK

Today / tomorrow — wan ni / phrung ni
How are you? — sabai dee mai?
I'm well — sabai dee
Beautiful — suay
Friend — phuean
Good luck — chok dee

EMERGENCIES

Help! — chuay duay!
Hospital — rong phayaban
Police — tamruat
I'm lost — chan long thang
Call a doctor — riak mor

Thai is tonal, so don't worry about perfection — a warm 'sawatdee khrap/kha' and a smile open every door. Men end politely with 'khrap', women with 'kha'.

BEFORE YOU GO (AGAIN)

Go slowly, see deeply

If there's one idea to carry into Thailand, it's this: resist the urge to see everything. The travellers who fall hardest for this country are the ones who slow down — who spend a third morning at the same coffee stall until the owner knows their order, who take the long road over the loop, who say yes to the invitation they didn't plan for.

Eat the thing you can't name. Learn the ten words. Give way to the smiles. Thailand will meet you more than halfway.

A FEW GOOD RESOURCES

- Tourism Authority of Thailand — tourismthailand.org
- 12Go — trains, buses & ferries
- Richard Barrow — long-running Thailand travel blog
- Grab / Bolt — rides & food
- Google Maps (offline) + Translate (Thai)
- Your travel insurer's 24-hour line





Chok dee

Good luck, and travel gently.



THE SLOW ATLAS · RENNES, FRANCE